

	Protection Mechanism	Duration	Registration Required	Disclosure Trade-off
Patent	Government-granted exclusive right to exclude others	20 years from filing date	Yes — patent application required	Full public disclosure of invention
Trade Secret	Confidentiality (NDAs, access controls)	Indefinite while secrecy maintained	No — protection is automatic	No disclosure; lost if secret is revealed
Copyright	Exclusive right to copy, distribute, derive	Life + 70 years (author); 95 years (work for hire)	No — automatic on creation	Work must be expressed and observable
Trademark	Brand identifier (name, logo, slogan)	Indefinite with continued use & renewal	Optional but strongly recommended	Public use required to maintain rights